

WHAT WERE THEY THINKING?

Not all products are equal, we know that, but then there are others that just make you wonder what the makers were smoking!

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HD DVD

When DVDs were past their prime, and the future of optical media was being debated, HD-DVD came to the fore, feeling like Superman come to planet Earth to give digital data hoarders and the entertainment industry a much needed shot in the arm. To cut a long, boring story short, HD-DVD – the future of DVDs as Toshiba had envisaged – now resides in the dustbin. While it offered more storage space (15GB) than a dual-layered DVD, HD-DVD couldn't build consensus among partners and quickly perished after a hasty launch back in 2006. It had no chance against the Sony-backed Blu-ray discs which packed in 25GB of data on a single layer. And with major movie studios preferring Sony's Blu-ray, Toshiba had to lick its wounds, accept market realities and release its own Blu-ray player in early 2009 – the ultimate insult!

Windows Vista

Seriously, what was Microsoft thinking when they launched Vista? The OS wasn't too different from Windows XP, didn't offer a killer set of features, and UAC annoyed everyone and their grandmother to no end. Sure, a steady stream of pre-release wallpapers and themes (Longhorn, anyone?) had piqued people's interest about the upcoming operating system's fresh new look and feel,

but Microsoft's cheeky recommendation for people to ramp up their hardware to run Vista's heavy cosmetic effects (Aero and whatnot) wasn't too compelling, and we actually though Vista was slower than XP. As a result, Microsoft Vista never struck a chord among retail customers, and neither wooed its business and enterprise clients for big



Vista – something we all want to forget

ticket orders (a substantial part of Microsoft's business). The result was that Vista became the most disappointing product launched by Microsoft, so disappointing that people wouldn't switch to it even for "free"!

Apple Maps

Earlier this year, Apple released iOS 6 which included a ton of new features. Hidden among those was a replacement for Google

Maps – Apple's very own Maps app. Apple's map app had a LOT of glitches, so much so that one wondered if it was designed and put together in a drug-induced stupor. Markers were off, straight roads appeared wavy, structures were flattened and entire cities were missing! One funny online comic paying homage to Apple's map app disaster suggested that the team field-testing the new feature got lost (obviously!) and couldn't find their way back in time to inform Tim Cook that it wasn't ready for launch. For a company striving towards perfection in everything they do, this was a huge product and PR disaster for Apple; and not surprisingly, Christmas had come early for Apple bashers! The half-baked app was inspiration for a lot of gags, and made Tim Cook, Apple's CEO, apologise publicly for the first time ever.

Blackberry Playbook

After Apple launched the iPad and started dominating the tablet market throughout 2010, every other brand worth its salt assaulted the iPad with competing offerings. It was only a matter of time before RIM, the fabled Blackberry phone maker, would join the party. So when RIM suggested "Amateur hour is over" in one of its first advertisement of the Playbook (its answer to the Apple iPad) customers were expecting a compelling tablet that would blow the competition away. The Playbook was anything but compelling, and RIM's marketing words would come back to hound the company.